



The Record Behind the Bolt

Student copy (project or hand out)

- 1 On June 4 a Lufthansa Dreamliner sat at gate A15 in Frankfurt with its nose on the tarmac. The jet was five months old. It had flown 137 times. A locking pin meant to hold the nose gear down had been set in the wrong position, and the gear folded while the plane was being readied for Los Angeles. Two cabin crew and several ground workers were taken to the hospital before a single passenger had boarded.
- 2 The pin itself was a maintenance mistake, and a British Airways 787 collapsed the same way at Heathrow in 2021 for the same reason. That much Boeing can set aside. What it cannot set aside is the record that was already on file when the gear gave way, a record the public had been told would be managed.
- 3 Three months before Frankfurt, the FAA proposed mandatory inspections of every 787 in the fleet for fatigue cracks at the splice plates where the wing joins the body: gaps past the engineering limit, preload past what the fasteners were built to bear, cracks waiting at the bolt holes. Boeing kept delivering the airplanes. In 2024 the agency audited the company for six weeks and watched it fail thirty-three of eighty-nine checks, most of them on the manufacturing controls meant to keep exactly this from happening. The line kept moving. That same year Boeing conceded its South Carolina workers had falsified inspection records on wing-to-body joins, and a federal memo found contaminated composite on more than a thousand Dreamliners, some bonded below the strength the design required.
- 4 Set the two columns side by side. In one, a paper trail of cracks, falsified records, contaminated parts, and audits failed. In the other, the same jets rolling off the line and into the gates, carrying the people who never saw the file.
- 5 When a regulator lets each audit stand alone with no data tying them together, when the company it watches cuts roughly nine hundred quality inspectors in two years and the agency's own inspector general reports that nobody tracks whether the same violations keep recurring, the question stops being whether another part will fail. It becomes which one, and when, and who is standing under it.
- 6 Who answers for a risk that was written down, costed out, and waved through?
- 7 The nose gear at Frankfurt is one bolt set wrong on one morning. The record behind it is years of warnings managed by press release. We are the passengers in the second column. We hold the vote, the hearing, the contract, the attention that decides whether a documented danger gets fixed or gets filed. The plane was new. Make them answer for the rest.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the fourth paragraph (the two columns) and the fifth paragraph (the regulator and the inspectors) is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) concedes that the maintenance error was unavoidable and then withdraws the charge against the manufacturer
 - B) predicts a future accident and then supplies the statistics that have already confirmed it
 - C) sets the documented failures against continued production and then names the oversight gaps that let the contradiction persist
 - D) contrasts Boeing with its regulator and then argues the regulator is the more culpable of the two
2. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's tone across the final paragraph?
 - A) Resigned pessimism that treats further accidents as beyond anyone's control
 - B) Detached neutrality that lays out the failures without taking a side
 - C) Measured indictment that hands the reader a duty to act
 - D) Sweeping outrage that condemns commercial aviation as a whole

Discussion questions:

1. The writer separates the nose gear pin (a maintenance error) from the manufacturing record (cracks, falsified inspections, contaminated parts) and insists the two are not the same problem. Why open with the incident that is not Boeing's manufacturing fault before turning to the failures that are? What does that sequence buy the argument?
2. The piece never says the shim gap defect caused the Frankfurt collapse, and in fact denies any link. How does the writer build a charge of accountability without claiming the documented defects caused this specific accident, and is that a fair move or an unfair one?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that an organization can be held accountable for a pattern of documented, inadequately managed risk even when that pattern did not cause the specific failure in front of the public. Write an essay in which you defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that accountability for known risk does not depend on proving that the known risk caused the particular harm. Use evidence from your own reading, observation, study, or experience to support your line of reasoning.